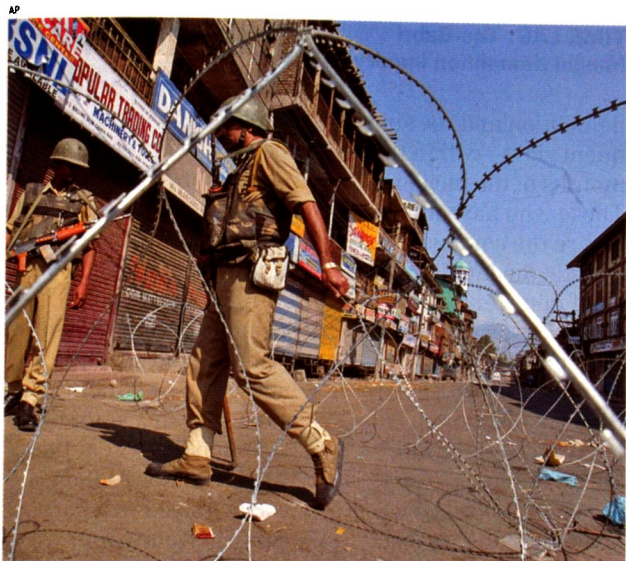




BATTLE OF NERVES: Curfew in Srinagar

transfer controversy has kept the Valley on the boil. Kashmir witnessed some of the largest ever mass anti-India demonstrations in August.

The Government is hoping that the scheduled beginning of cross-LOC trade on October 21 would once again calm tempers in Kashmir. But the shaky Srinagar-Muzaffarabad bus service does not allow for much cross-border trade. While militancy related violence is at an all-time low, the Valley's Catch-22 is fast transforming into a battle of nerves.

The playing field is political again. An Election Commission team is in the state to assess the preparedness of the administration to hold the Assembly polls. However, official sources say that the administration is prepared to put thousands of separatist activists and leaders behind bars soon to make another election possible in the state.

by Aljaz Hussain

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Freedom fighter **Laxmi Panda**, former member of Subhash Chandra Bose's Indian National Army. She was not provided freedom fighters' pension and was forced to do odd jobs as a domestic help to earn a living.



DIED: R.S. Lodha, 66, former FICCI president and heir to Priyamvada Devi Birla's

Rs 5,000-crore legacy. Priyamvada was the widow of industrialist M.P. Birla.

WON: By shuttler **Chetan Anand**, the men's singles title at the Bitburger Open in Germany, while **V. Diju** and **Jwala Gutta** won the mixed doubles event.

AWARDED: To filmmaker and naturalist **Shekhar Dattatri**, the Edberg Award for his work with conservation and environmental awareness in India. The award is constituted by the Edberg Foundation in Sweden.

Kashmir Conundrum

SRINAGAR On October 6, a stringent curfew was imposed across the Valley to ensure that a mass rally by separatists was scuttled. But in the prevailing Catch-22 situation for the state administration, whatever it does to halt the increasing separatist momentum in the Valley gets translated into "victory for separatism".

If they allow it, hundreds of thousands of people come out in support of right to self-

determination. If they clamp down, separatists call it a "moral victory" and the unrealised call for a mass demonstration remains a potent weapon in their piggybank.

Sources say separatists have now reserved a fresh call for a mass rally, a "Lal Chowk chalo", for the day when polls will be held in the Valley around December to avoid extending Governor's rule in the state. Since June, the Amarnath land

VIS-A-VIS **JULIO RIBEIRO** former Mumbai Police commissioner **versus** **RAJ THACKERAY** Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief

“How can one man, merely because he aspires to step into his uncle's (Bal Thackeray) shoes, hold the city to ransom?”



SAURABH SINGH

“Don't hurt our pride and self-respect. Mumbai does not belong to your father either.”

EPILOGUE: The right to living in Mumbai is now the father of all battles.

HOTEL

